

CONSTRUCTING CLEAR SENTENCES & PARAGRAPHS

CHAPTER 4

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- *Explain the role of adaptation in writing clear sentences.*
- *Write short, clear sentences by limiting sentence content and economising on words.*
- *Design sentences that give the right emphasis to content.*
- *Employ unity and good logic in writing effective sentences.*
- *Compose paragraphs that are short and unified, use topic sentences effectively, and communicate coherently.*

CARE IN SENTENCE DESIGN

Limit Sentence Content

- *Write simple, efficient sentences over long, complex ones.*
- *Save your readers time.*
- *Prevent miscommunication.*
- *Don't give too much information in one sentence.*

LIMIT SENTENCE CONTENT

- *Design sentences based on the reader's ability.*
- *However, overuse of short sentences can result in a choppy and elementary-sounding effect.*
- *Use moderately long sentences occasionally to de-emphasise less important content and increase variety.*
- *Too much information in one sentence can cause confusion.*

REWRITE THE PARAGRAPH USING SHORT, CLEAR SENTENCES

- *Regardless of their seniority or union affiliation, all employees who hope to be promoted are expected to continue their education either by enrolling in the special courses to be offered by the company, which are scheduled to be given after working hours beginning next Wednesday, or by taking approved online courses selected from a list, which can be found on the company portal.*

ECONOMISE ON WORDS

- Shorter wordings save the reader time.
 - Usually clearer and more interesting.
 - **Cluttering Phrase-** a phrase that can be replaced by shorter wording without loss of meaning.
1. *In the event that* payment is not made by January, operations will cease.
 2. *If* payment is not made by January, operations will cease.

REMOVE THE CLUTTERING PHRASE, USING SHORTER SUBSTITUTION

1. *In very few cases*
2. *In the meantime*
3. *For the reason that*
4. *At the present time*
5. *With regard to*

SURPLUS WORDS

- We often use meaningless extra words as a matter of habit.
 - These are known as **Surplus words**, which can often be left out.
1. *It will be noted that* the records for the past years show a steady increase in special appropriations.

ELIMINATE SURPLUS WORDS

1. The machines that were damaged by the fire were repaired.
2. There are four rules that should be observed.
3. I am prepared to report to the effect that sales increased.

ROUNDABOUT CONSTRUCTIONS

- You can write the same information in many ways.
- Use direct ways instead of roundabout constructions.
- Direct ways are shorter and communicate better.

WRITE IN DIRECT ORDER

- The department budget can be observed to be decreasing each new year.
- The price increase will afford the company an opportunity to retire the debt.

REPETITION

- Repeating words adds to the sentence length.
- It is often without purpose as it doesn't add anything to the meaning.
- Example- He stated that he believes that we are responsible.

ELIMINATE REPETITIVE WORDS

1. Please endorse your name on the back of this cheque.
2. Tod Wilson is the present incumbent.
3. At the present time, we are conducting two clinics.

MANAGE EMPHASIS IN SENTENCE DESIGN

- Use short sentences for emphasis.
- They get the attention by conveying a single message without supporting information.
- Short openings enable you to get to the point quickly.
- Short closing leaves the reader with an important final thought.

INDEPENDENT AND DEPENDENT CLAUSE

- When a sentence contains two or more ideas, the ideas share emphasis.
- How they share it depends on how the sentence is constructed.
- Coordinated- two ideas get equal emphasis.
- Subordinated- one idea gets more emphasis than the other.

INDEPENDENT AND DEPENDENT CLAUSE

- ***Equal emphasis:***

1. The company lost money last year. The loss occurred despite record sales.
2. The company lost money last year, and the loss occurred despite record sales.

- ***Emphasis on the lost money:***

3. Although the company enjoyed record sales last year, it lost money.

- ***Emphasis on the sales increase:***

4. The company enjoyed record sales last year, although it lost money.

GIVE SENTENCE UNITY

- Good sentences have unity.
- All the parts of the sentence work together to create one clear point.
- Lack of unity is usually caused by one of two problems-
 1. Unrelated Ideas
 2. Excessive Detail

UNRELATED IDEAS

- . Give sentences unity in 3 ways.

Mr. Jordan is our sales manager, and he has a degree in law.

1.Put the ideas in separate sentences.

Mr. Jordan is our sales manager. He has a law degree.

2.Subordinate one of the ideas to the other.

Mr. Jordan, our sales manager, has a law degree.

3.Add words to show how the ideas are related.

Although Mr. Jordan is our sales manager, he has a degree in law.

UNRELATED IDEAS

- *Using the cost-of-living calculator is simple, but no tool will work well unless it is explained clearly.*

EXCESSIVE DETAIL

- Putting too much detail into one sentence hides the central thought.
- It can also make the sentence long.
- If the detail isn't necessary, remove it.

EXCESSIVE DETAIL

- *Because of our New York offices, which were considered plush in the 1990s, are now badly in need of renovation, as is the case with most offices that have not been maintained, we recommend closing them and finding a new location.*

WORD SENTENCES LOGICALLY

.Mixed constructions- mix two different kinds of sentences together.

Sentence 1: *First we found less expensive material, and then a more economical means of production was developed.*

Sentence 2: *First we found less expensive material, and then we developed a more economical means of production.*

MIXED CONSTRUCTION

- *My education was completed in 2009, and then i began work as a manager for Home Depot.*

INCOMPLETE CONSTRUCTIONS

- Certain words used early in a sentence signal that the rest of the sentence will provide a certain kind of content.
- Be careful to fulfil your reader's expectations.
- Otherwise you will have written an incomplete construction.
- Example: ***She was so happy with the retirement party we gave her.***

MISPLACED/DANGLING MODIFIERS

- Putting modifiers in the wrong place.
- Giving them nothing to modify in the sentence.
- Example: ***Believing the price would drop, the purchasing agents were instructed not to buy.***
- Correct the sentence above.

FAULTY PARALLELISM

- Readers expect the same kinds of content in a sentence to be worded in the same way.
- Example: *To create a more appealing website, we can gather personal stories, create a new logo, as well as making the layout more readable.*

PARAGRAPH DESIGN

- Paragraphs should have unity.
 - Keep paragraphs short.
 - Make good use of topic sentences.
 - Topic sentence- expresses the main idea of a paragraph, and the remaining sentences build around and support it.
1. Topic sentence first
 2. Topic sentence at the end
 3. Topic sentence within the paragraph
- Leave out unnecessary detail

PARAGRAPH DESIGN

- Make paragraphs coherent.
 1. Repetition of key words and ideas.
 2. Use of pronouns.
 3. Transitional words.